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Week-02

Chapter # 02

Introduction to the Islam

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Introduction to Islam

Islam (اسلام) is the name of a famous religion amongst the religions of the world. It is the religion of truth containing both thoughts and practices. According to the divine scripture 'Qur'an', it is the true religion with Allah the Exalted and the final and complete version of the Divine guidance.

Etymology

The word "Islam (اسلام)" is an Arabic word derived from "Salama (سلم)" which literally means "Peace" and "Safeness". The word "Islam (اسلام)" literally means "Obedience", "Submission" and "Surrender".

Definition & Concept

A complete code of life revealed by Allah (The Creator, the Owner, the Sustainer & the Lord) to His Prophets & Messengers (From Adam AS to the last of His messengers Muhammad PBUH) from time to time to guide His slaves (Mankind & Jinn) for their success in life and afterlife.

Important Note 1:

Islam is unlike other religions as they contain some typical traditions and customs particularly at three occasions i.e. the birth of a child, the marriage and the death of a person, or maximum some rituals are being performed as worships. They do not have systematic and organized structure of worships, family dealings, social dealings, economic system, political and legal affairs based upon their religion.

On the other hand, Islam is a complete code of life and is fully equipped with teachings for every aspect of life. For instance, along with above mentioned disciplines of life, Islam also stresses upon daily routine of life such as eating, drinking, sleeping, dressing, and also commands to perform the necessities of daily life, as per the commandments of Islam.

Secondly, Islam is a divine religion set, chosen and revealed by Allah (The Creator, The Owner and The Lord of all the worlds). It is not a man-made religion. Its teachings are genuinely from The Lord and are beyond doubts. Allah the Almighty has sent its last version of Divine guidance to the last of His Messengers, Prophet Muhammad (PBUH) through one of His angels Jibrael AS who is considered as the chief of all of the angels as described by Almighty the Allah. He reveals in the Qur'an;

And truly, this is the revelation from the lord of all worlds. The trustworthy spirit (Jibrael) brought it down. Upon your heart, so that you may become one of the warners. In plain Arabic language.¹

The Subject of Islam:

The Subject refers towards the study of some particular thing or object which, as a topic, is discussed under a discipline. For example, human body is discussed under medical

¹ Quran-26:192-195

science. Therefore, it is the subject of medical science. And machine is the subject of engineering because it is discussed under the discipline of engineering.

In the same way, when Islam is considered as a discipline and the code for life, definitely there should be some subject to be discussed in it too. And the subject for the entire Islamic teachings is the human beings and Jinns being slaves to Allah the Exalted, as He says:

“I did not create mankind and Jinn except for the Purpose that they should worship me.”²

Islam reveals the teachings through which human beings may enable themselves to become good slaves to Allah the Almighty.

The Objective of Islam:

The objective behind this revelation of Islam is:

"To provide complete guidance to mankind and Jinn that leads them to the success in life and afterlife".

A noteworthy point should also be remembered that the actual concept of success, as per the interpretation of divine scripture Al-Qur'an, lies down with safe removal from the fire of hell and the entrance into paradise. Allah says:

"So, whoever is safely removed from the fire of Hell and admitted to Paradise, he succeeded indeed. And the worldly life is not but the goods of delusion".³

The verse reveals that beyond this actual success, no worldly success is appreciable and reliable especially when this world itself is a mortal and until the man is safely removed from the fire of Hell.

Fore face of Islam:

In a very famous Hadith of Prophet Muhammad (PBUH), entitled with Hadith-e-Jibrael, Prophet PBUH introduced Islam by its face features as a reply to a question asked by Jibreel AS. For details, Hazrat Umar RA. reports that once Jibreel AS came to see Prophet PBUH in the attire of a man while some of the companions (including reporter) were sitting around him in the holy mosque of Madinah. He asked few questions which were replied by the Prophet PBUH.

1: Islam

Jibrael asked the Prophet PBUH about Islam, to which he replied that it consists of five pillars:

Shahada: Declaration of faith in the oneness of God and the prophet hood of Prophet Muhammad PBUH.

Salah: Performing the five daily prayers.

Zakat: Giving alms to the poor and needy.

Sawm: Fasting during the month of Ramadan.

² Quran-51:56

³ Quran-3:185

Hajj: Pilgrimage to Mecca for those who are able.

2: Iman (Faith):

Jibrael AS then asked about **Iman** (faith), and the Prophet PBUH explained that it involves belief in:

Allah (God)

His angels

His books

His messengers

The Day of Judgment

Predestination (that good and bad are decreed by Allah).

3: Ihsan (Excellence in Worship):

Jibrael AS asked about **Ihsan**, and the Prophet PBUH explained that it is to worship Allah as if you see Him, and even though you do not see Him, you should know that He sees you.⁴

It is important to note that the teachings mentioned above represent only a small portion of Islamic teachings, not the entirety of Islam. Just as a person has organs and body parts beyond just the features of the face, Islam encompasses much more than what has been outlined here.

The Structure of Islam

Islam

└─ I. Foundations

- | └─ 1. Tawheed (Oneness of God)
- | └─ 2. Risalah (Prophethood)
- | └─ 3. Akhirah (Hereafter)

└─ II. Religious Structure

| └─ A. Beliefs (Iman – 6 Articles)

- └─ Believe in oneness of God
- └─ Believe in the Prophets
- └─ Believe in Angels
- └─ Believe in holy Books

⁴ Sahih Muslim:93

- Believe in the Day of Judgment
 - Believe in the Desitny
 - | — **B. Practices (Ibadah – 5 Pillars)**
 - Shahadah
 - Salah/Prayer
 - Sawm/Fasting
 - Zakah/Obligatory Charity
 - Hajj/Pilgrimage
 - | — **C. Sources of Law/Jurisprudence**
 - | — Qur'an
 - | — Sunnah
 - | — Ijma (Consensus)
 - | — Qiyas (Analogy)
- **III. Islamic Systems**
 - | — **A. Social System**
 - | — Esteem system of Soul/Human Dignity
 - | — Family structure
 - | — Marriage & divorce laws
 - | — Gender roles
 - | — Rights of neighbors, orphans, etc.
 - | — **B. Ethical System**
 - | — Halal vs Haram
 - | — Personal integrity
 - | — Justice ('Adl)
 - | — Social values
 - | — Antiquates
 - | — Accountability before God
 - | — **C. Political System**
 - | — Shura (Consultation)

- | | | — Caliphate / Imamate concepts
- | | | — Governance under Sharia
- | | | — Justice & law enforcement
- | | — **D. Economic System**
- | | — Zakat (Wealth purification)
- | | — Prohibition of Riba (Interest)
- | | — Islamic banking & finance
- | | — Principles of fair trade & charity

Why Islam?

The authenticity of Islam is often highlighted by the experiences of converts in Europe, the UK, and the USA, who find its teachings deeply compelling and transformative. Many converts are drawn to Islam's clear monotheism, the emphasis on personal responsibility, and the sense of belonging to a global community. The Qur'an's timeless and unaltered preservation, coupled with the simplicity and coherence of its message, offers a sense of authenticity that resonates with individuals seeking spiritual fulfillment and clarity in a complex world. Converts often speak of the inner peace they find in Islam's structured way of life, its emphasis on justice, and its comprehensive moral guidance, all of which stand in contrast to the perceived emptiness or disillusionment in other aspects of contemporary life. The growing number of conversions in these regions reflects Islam's enduring authenticity and relevance, as individuals from diverse backgrounds embrace its message of faith, unity, and purpose.

Islam's growth and appeal can be understood through several aspects that highlight its unique approach to spirituality, ethics, and societal structure, from an objective standpoint. Here are five factors that explain why many people choose to convert to Islam and find it compelling:

Monotheism (Tawhid) and Simplicity of God:

Islam's core belief in the absolute oneness of God (Tawhid) offers a simplified and clear understanding of divinity. In comparison to some other religious systems that involve complex theological frameworks or multiple deities, Islam's strict monotheism is straightforward, emphasizing the singularity and indivisibility of God. This simplicity can be an appealing factor for those seeking a direct, unambiguous concept of God. Converts, including notable figures like Cat Stevens (Yusuf Islam), have mentioned that the clear, monotheistic nature of Islam resonated deeply with them, especially in contrast to other religious concepts they had encountered.

Holistic Approach to Life:

Islam provides a comprehensive way of life that extends beyond spirituality to include social, ethical, and legal guidelines. This approach covers all aspects of human existence, such as family life, business ethics, community service, and moral behavior. This holistic structure appeals to those seeking order, meaning, and purpose in their lives. Converts, such as Lauren Booth, a British journalist who converted to Islam, have spoken

about how Islam's all-encompassing framework gave them a sense of direction and clarity in everyday decisions, including family and work-related matters.

Universal Message for Humanity:

Islam is viewed as a universal message, not restricted to any particular culture or geographic region. It presents itself as a final, complete revelation for all humanity. This inclusiveness has made it appealing to a diverse range of individuals across the globe. Islam's emphasis on social justice, equality, and global brotherhood speaks to those looking for a faith that unites people beyond borders. Kristiane Backer, a German television personality who converted to Islam, has described how the universal nature of Islam, which emphasizes common values and shared human experience, was a key factor in her decision to embrace the faith.

Emphasis on Justice, Equality, and Social Welfare:

Islam's emphasis on justice and equality has been a central tenet of its appeal. The religion advocates for fair treatment of all individuals, irrespective of their social status, race, or ethnicity. The principle of charity (Zakat), which mandates Muslims to give a portion of their wealth to those in need, supports social welfare and addresses issues of inequality. In many conversion stories, individuals mention the appeal of Islam's social justice teachings. For instance, Muhammad Asad, a prominent convert and scholar, embraced Islam because of its ethical teachings and the religion's focus on addressing social inequalities and promoting the welfare of society.

The Qur'an as a Timeless Source of Knowledge:

The Qur'an is regarded by Muslims as the literal and unaltered word of God, preserved over time in its original form. For many converts, the intellectual and spiritual depth of the Qur'an is a compelling factor. Its linguistic beauty, combined with its teachings on ethics, law, and spirituality, has been highlighted by converts as a source of profound wisdom. Dr. Garry Miller, Dr. Lawrence Brown, Yusuf Estes and many other converted scholars have advocated this fact.

Khadija Patel, a journalist and convert to Islam, has spoken about how the Qur'an's intellectual depth and its capacity to address both individual and societal concerns provided a powerful reason for her conversion.

These factors show how Islam's unique spiritual, ethical, and societal aspects appeal to a broad audience. The conversion stories of individuals from different backgrounds illustrate how these principles resonate with those seeking a clearer, more structured path in life, offering a balanced approach to personal, social, and spiritual fulfillment.

In the end, it is also important to understand the status of Islam in the eyesight of Allah, the Lord of all the worlds. According to the divine scripture Qur'an, the concept of the finality of Islam contains following two points;

Finality of Islam

1: Islam (The final version, revealed upon Prophet PBUH) is the only religion with Allah the Almighty in true sense.

"Truly, the religion with Allah is Islam".⁵

Also one should not die without believing and following Islam. As Allah has warned clearly in Qur'an stating;

"O you, who believe, be afraid of Allah, as He deserves to be feared, and let not yourself die save as Muslims."⁶

2: The concept of success in true sense i.e. the success in afterlife totally depends upon following this final version of Islam, and there is no other possible way or key to success. No other religion is acceptable to Allah, the Lord and the Master of the Day of Judgment. Allah has announced it in Qur'an saying,

"And whoever seeks a religion other than Islam, It will never be accepted from him, and he, in the hereafter, will be among the losers".⁷

Also, dying without having faith in this final version of Islam will cause the definite & eternal punishment in Hell. Allah states;

"Those who disbelieve and die as disbelievers, an earth-full of gold even shall never be accepted from any of them, even if one were to offer it as ransom. They are the ones for whom there is a painful punishment, and for them there are no helpers."⁸

It has been categorically communicated in a hadith in following words:

Abu Huraira g narrated that the Messenger a of Allah said; "I swear by the one who holds the life of Muhammad, any of the Jew or Christian from among the people who comes to know about me, and then dies without having faith in what I have been sent with (Islam), he will definitely be among the hell members".⁹

⁵ Quran-3:19

⁶ Quran-3:102

⁷ Quran-3:85

⁸ Quran-3:91

⁹ Sahih Muslim:386